

CHARLES KITONGA

Software Development Engineer in Test (SDET) & QA Engineering Lead

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PROFILE

Quality engineering leader and software engineer with 5+ years delivering enterprise-scale telecommunications and fintech platforms across Kenya and Ethiopia. Proven track record leading cross-functional QA teams of up to 10 engineers, embedding automation-first testing strategy, and partnering with engineering and product leadership to raise release confidence. Deep hands-on experience in API and UI automation (Selenium, Rest Assured, Cucumber), performance testing (K6, JMeter), and React/JavaScript-based frontend validation.

CORE SKILLS

- **Automation & Testing:** Selenium, Rest Assured, Robot Framework, Cucumber, Postman, K6, JMeter
- **Programming:** Java, JavaScript / React, Python
- **QA Leadership & Process:** Test strategy & planning, team leadership & mentoring, release readiness, Agile/Scrum
- **CI/CD & Quality Ops:** Jenkins, SonarQube, Allure Reports

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Safaricom PLC—Software Development Engineer in Test (SDET) *Aug 2024 – Present*

- Own QA for device-financing products (Pay-As-You-Go, Lipa Na Bonga), directly supporting payment success rates and revenue enablement for a national customer base.
- Partner with engineering teams to ship Lipa Na Bonga payment integrations, driving adoption of alternative payment channels and improving transaction reliability.
- Test backend statement and transaction-history APIs, closing accuracy gaps in financial data before release.
- Run performance testing with K6 to surface system bottlenecks early, improving production readiness across release cycles.
- Rotate into frontend QA, validating React-based UI workflows to improve end-to-end web journey quality.
- Coordinate across QA, frontend, and backend teams to tighten release cadence and cross-functional handoffs.
- Piloted AI-assisted testing practices for exploratory test design and defect analysis, expanding coverage planning efficiency.

Safaricom Telecommunications Ethiopia PLC—SDET/QA Team Lead, *Apr 2022–Jun 2024*

- Led and coordinated a 10-member quality engineering team across testing strategy, execution, and delivery for prepaid and postpaid telecom platforms, ensuring high-quality, on-time releases.
- Established QA processes, test planning standards, and quality gates, mentoring engineers and driving continuous improvement team-wide.
- Built API automation using Rest Assured and Postman, materially increasing regression coverage and cutting manual regression effort.
- Developed UI and API automation frameworks with Selenium, Cucumber, and JMeter, raising release confidence and reducing the manual testing load.
- Led SIM Test Readiness and Device Readiness workstreams, enabling successful nationwide product rollouts.

- Designed and built an internal Test Data Management Tool (React + Spring Boot), cutting test-data preparation time and boosting team productivity.
- Partnered with product owners, developers, and business stakeholders to define quality gates and resolve critical production risks.

Safaricom PLC—SDET, Technology Division, Feb 2022 – Apr 2022

- Improved sprint delivery and backlog management through Agile/Scrum practices; used Six Sigma techniques to reduce defect rates.
- Executed manual and automated (Selenium) testing for the eKYC application and managed CRM test cases, improving defect-resolution speed.
- Performed JMeter performance testing to identify system bottlenecks; finalist, Safaricom Hackathon (Event Wallet Platform).

Upscale Technologies—Software Developer, Jan 2021–Sep 2021

- Built UI applications with Vue.js, Pug, and GraphQL; refactored to the Vue Composition API to reduce technical debt. Mentored an incoming intern and conducted GitHub code reviews to improve release reliability.

Earlier Roles Feb 2017 – Dec 2020

- Skillsday Limited, Software Engineer (2020): Built features for a Laravel-based LMS and integrated Mpesa STK Push for streamlined payments.
- Payflick Limited, Software Developer & Technical Support (2020): Built an ordering and delivery system using Python and React.
- Your Apps Ltd / Defense Forces Canteen Organization, IT Support & Internships (2017–2019): Help desk, networking, and systems support; cut IT issue response time by 40%.

PROFESSIONAL QUALIFICATIONS

- Certified Tester Foundation Level (ISTQB)
- Scrum Fundamentals Certified (SCRUMStudy)
- Six Sigma Yellow Belt Professional (6SigmaStudy)
- Microsoft Certified: Azure Fundamentals (AZ-900)
- Certified Public Accountant – Part 1 (Strathmore University)

EDUCATION

- B.Sc. Business Information Technology, Business Intelligence Major (Second Class Upper Division)—Strathmore University, 2017–2019
- Diploma in Business Information Technology—Strathmore University, 2016
- Kenya Certificate of Secondary Education — St. Charles Lwanga School, Kitui, 2011–2014